

Overview of Grammar: Words

Basic Linguistic Theory, Vol. 1-2, Dixon (2010)

- **Word:** surprisingly difficult to define
 - **Practical:** anything that is between two spaces
 - But: what about spoken language?
 - what about phrases whose spaces disappeared?
("kick start", "kickstart" or "kick-start"?)
 - What about languages that don't have spaces?
(e.g., Mandarin Chinese)



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- Sapir (1921): “one of the smallest, completely satisfying bits of isolated meaning into which the sentence resolves itself”
- Zirmunskij (1966): “the word is the most concise unit of language, which is independent in meaning and form”
- Bloomfield (1933): “a word, then, is a free form which does not consist entirely of (two or more) lesser free forms; in brief, a word is a *minimum free form*”
 - “free form” is interpreted to mean words that can occur on their own, with a given meaning
 - But: many words (“the”, “my”, “and”) cannot occur on their own

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- We will distinguish between:
 - **Phonological words:** defined by phonological criteria, primarily: syllable structure, pause phenomena, prosodic features (such as stress or tone), phonological word boundary rules
 - **Grammatical words:** have a conventionalized meaning, can undergo morphological processes (e.g., affixation, reduplication, vowel shift)